

The Lost Temples of Nagapattinam and Quanzhou: A study in Sino-Indian Relations

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Nagapattinam, on the coast of Tamilnadu in south India and Quanzhou, in Fujian, south China, are today small, provincial towns of modest economic importance. Yet in the course of the tenth to thirteenth centuries these two ports were axial points around which a great international trade flourished. Each city served as the major port through which international commerce was conducted between India and China and the West, linking these great realms in a highly profitable system of exchange in which both private merchants and ruling authorities were able to profit.

The 'lost temples' of this paper, a Chinese temple in south India and Hindu temples in south China, are the natural consequence of this international trade: places of worship erected either by expatriate merchant communities or the result of patronage from foreign rulers who sought to consolidate friendly relations with a major trading partner. As such, an attempt to reconstruct the nature of these temples and the circumstances under which they were erected is to enquire into the historical dynamics of medieval Asian trade itself.

I

In 1867 French Jesuit missionaries in Nagapattinam secured permission from the British authorities to demolish the Puduveli-gopuram for its building materials (Fig. 1). The tower was of brick construction, with timber lintels, irregularly square in plan and rising in a series of stepped stories. As early as 1615 it had attracted the attention of the Portuguese Jesuit Manuel Barradas, who provided the first European description of the tower and recounted the local beliefs regarding its origins. He reported that 'it is believed by these people [of Nagapattinam] to have been made by ... [the Chinese] when they were lords of the commerce of India: it is of brick, and despite been neither inhabited nor repaired for many centuries still is in its majesty, and in perfect condition.'⁽¹⁾ A century later a Dutch minister in the service of the Dutch East India Company (VOC), François Valentijn, writing after his return to Holland in 1714, referred to the tower as the 'Pagood China', supporting this historical association with Chinese merchants.⁽²⁾ When the tower was drawn in 1846 by a government draughtsman at the request of Walter Elliot, a British officer serving in south India, it consisted of three stories

only, rising to about 30 metres in height. Elliot provides the most complete description of the tower prior to its demolition: 'four-sided tower of three stories, constructed of bricks closely fitted together without cement, the first and second stories divided into corniced mouldings, with an opening for a door or window in the middle of each side'.⁽³⁾ Although, as Elliot observed, 'no trace of sculpture or inscription was visible' the discovery in March 1856 of a remarkable cache of five Buddhist images in a brick chamber adjacent to the tower, together with other finds in the immediate environs, established the religious affiliations of the site. Of the five Buddha images excavated in 1856, four were bronze whilst the fifth was described (in the contemporary French account of their discovery) as 'a mixture of porcelain and clay, of exquisite workmanship' (Fig. 2). This remarkable find (no longer traceable) appears, from the only surviving drawing published in 1878, to be Burmese in origin and probably dates from the fifteenth century, when Nagapattinam, by then an isolated outpost of Buddhism, had contact with the Kingdom of Pegu in lower Burma.⁽⁴⁾ The sculpture may have been donated by visiting Burmese merchants in thanksgiving for a safe journey. Manuel Barradas's account of 1615 claimed that Nagapattinam 'is of the greatest trade and commerce that there is now in India', citing as evidence trade with Melaka, Bengal, Pegu, Tenasserim and Ujangsalang.⁽⁵⁾ The discovery of this Burmese Buddha at Nagapattinam suggests significant commercial contact with Pegu.

The architectural style of the Buddhist structure associated with these finds does not conform with any known Indian architectural type. Rather, this style of tower has its most immediate prototype in the Buddhist pagodas of Chinese architecture of the Song and Yuan periods (eleventh-thirteenth centuries). This similarity was recognized by the earliest commentators who assumed that it was commissioned by a Chinese merchant community resident at Nagapattinam: witness Barradas's Chinese attribution of 1615. Earlier Chinese sources establish the reliability of the local informants recorded by Barradas. Wang Dayuan's *Dao yi zhi lue jiao yi* ('Brief Account of the Barbarian Isles') of 1350 refers to a Chinese community resident at Nagapattinam, who were responsible for having a temple built.⁽⁶⁾

Wang Dayuan also provides a description of a '*tuta* [earthen tower = stupa]⁽⁷⁾ to be found in the flat land of Pa-tan [Nagapattinam]' which could refer to the tower demolished in 1867. The *tuta* is described as being of brick construction and scores of feet high. According to this account it also had a dedicatory stone inscription in Chinese which recorded that 'the work was finished in the eighth moon of the third year *hien chw'en* [1267]'.⁽⁸⁾ Supporting evidence for this Chinese account appears in the 1476 Kalyani inscription of Pegu, which refers to the Padarikarama monastery at Nagapattinam built 'by command of the Maharaja of Chinadesa'.⁽⁹⁾

These descriptions of the temple at Nagapattinam are however not the earliest textual evidence for the existence of a Chinese temple in south India.

The *Kieou Tang Chou* records that in the ninth month of 720 'the king of South India Che-li-Na-lo-seng-k'ia-to-pa [the Pallava king Narasimhavarman II, 690-720] constructed a temple on account of the empire [i.e. China]'.⁽¹⁰⁾ The source does not state where the temple was built but it was most probably at either Kanchipuram, the Pallava capital, or their principal port, Mamallapuram. Evidently the volume of direct Chinese trade with south India had reached such a level as to justify the building of a temple for the benefit of visiting merchants.

Historically, pilgrim and missionary activity in Asia has tended to follow the routes established through the initiative of merchants and traders. The earliest Chinese account of maritime trade with the West, written by Pan Kou in the first century AD, states that such journeys were undertaken in 'the merchant ships of the foreigners [who] take them to their destination by turns'.⁽¹¹⁾ This is how the Chinese pilgrims continued to travel throughout the first millennium and it is unlikely that Chinese ships were seen on Indian shores in any numbers before the twelfth or thirteenth century.⁽¹²⁾

The religious and commercial dialogue between China and south India was already well established by the beginning of the eighth century. Among the earliest evidence of direct Chinese contact with Nagapattinam is the travel account of the Buddhist pilgrim I-tsing (670), who noted that this port was the landing point for Chinese pilgrims arriving in India by the sea route, after 'going west thirty days from Quedah [Kedah, Malay peninsula]'. The Chinese pilgrim Hiuen Tsiang (629) also appears to refer to Nagapattinam.⁽¹³⁾ This period also witnessed the rise of Guangzhou (Canton) as the pre-eminent port in China's trade relations with the *Nanhai* (Southern Ocean), India and the Arab lands of the West. This was coupled with an influx of foreign religions to China, most notably Islam, and a revitalized school of Buddhism. It was during this period that the Buddhist teacher Vajrabodhi (661-730), under the patronage of the Pallava king Narasimhavarman II, is believed to have gone to China to spread the teachings of Vajrayana, supposedly presenting a copy of the *Mahāprajñāpāramitā* text to the emperor in 720.⁽¹⁴⁾

Nagapattinam already existed as a port of some significance in this period, although secondary to Mamallapuram, which the Pallava rulers (575-900) had developed as their premier port to service their nearby capital of Kanchipuram. From the Chinese pilgrims' accounts, it is clear that merchant ships sailing from Southeast Asia used Nagapattinam as their preferred landfall. By the early tenth century Nagapattinam had, under Chola patronage, displaced Mamallapuram as the first port of the region and was being organized as a major commercial centre. The port generated great wealth for the Chola rulers whose agents were able to tax its commerce, leaving regulation of the trade largely in the hands of the Tamil merchant corporations.⁽¹⁵⁾

The eighth and ninth century saw the rise to prominence of Nagapattinam as a major Buddhist centre, a status it preserved until around the fifteenth century. The accounts of Chinese patronage of Buddhist temples in the Pallava and Chola periods provide a rare insight into the scale of Chinese participation in the maritime trade of south India. They also suggest that the Chinese role in international trade was far more active than has generally been assumed, and that the initial destination for the bulk of this trade was the Coromandel coast of south India.

The discovery of Chinese ceramics at Nagapattinam and other sites in south India, especially coastal Tamilnadu and the hinterland trading centres with easy riverine access to the sea, reflects one aspect of this trade. Recent finds indicate that this trade was more sustained than previously believed. Concentrations of finds have tended to occur at points of transshipment or distribution, such as ports, and at points of consumption, notably palaces, forts and temples. For example, the recent excavations at the early eleventh century palace site of the Chola capital of Gangaikondacholapuram, conducted by the Tamilnadu State Department of Archaeology, revealed eleventh-twelfth century white wares, and the port town of Periyapattinam has yielded recently reported finds of fourteenth century Longquan celadon and Jingdezhen blue-and-white.⁽¹⁶⁾ Ming period blue-and-white and enamel wares found at Vellore fort (inland from Madras), at the Vijayanagar capital at Hampi in southern Karnataka and also at Golconda fort, Hyderabad, all point to a continuation of this trade into the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries and beyond. The presence of Chinese coins on the south Indian coast has also been noted, first reported by Col. Colin MacKenzie at the beginning of the nineteenth century.⁽¹⁷⁾

The Chinese were not the only foreign trading power to patronize religious establishments in south India. A copper-plate inscription records the establishment of a Buddhist temple (*palli*) and monastery (*vihāra*) at Nagapattinam by the ruler of Srivijaya in the 21st year of the Chola ruler Rajaraja I's reign (1006).⁽¹⁸⁾ Rajaraja I in turn granted the temple the revenue of a village, an endowment confirmed by his son, Rajendra. This Chola support was reaffirmed by king Kulottunga some 85 years later.⁽¹⁹⁾ The patronage of a foreign Buddhist establishment by a succession of Hindu rulers underscores the economic importance which the Cholas attached to maintaining cordial relations with foreign trading states.

This concern for commercial diplomacy was reflected in the number of missions the Cholas sent to China, which began in 1015 and continued throughout their reign.⁽²⁰⁾ It extended to funding the restoration of temples in Guangzhou: a stone inscription dated 1079, discovered in a dilapidated Taoist temple in Guangzhou in 1957, records a foreign donor who funded the restoration of Taoist and Buddhist temples, together with the donation of the cost of ricefields for the maintenance of the monks and nuns. The donor is

named as Kulottunga I, the powerful Chola ruler (1070-1118) who is described as the 'lord of *San-fo-ch'i*', the Song transcription for Srivijaya.⁽²¹⁾ Srivijaya, a major entrepot state strategically situated in Sumatra on the international trade route, was by this time in decline and her tenuous control over long-distance trade appears to have been underwritten by the Chola navy, following the Chola raids of 1025.⁽²²⁾ The 1079 Guangzhou inscription points to a significant portion of Guangzhou's international trade of the later eleventh century being conducted by vessels under Chola control.

II

South Indian merchant corporations also actively promoted trade abroad. The presence of Tamil-speaking merchant communities is well attested in insular Southeast Asia. Tamil inscriptions found at Takuapa in the Malay peninsula (c. ninth century)⁽²³⁾, Labu Tuwa near Pansur on the west coast of Sumatra (dated Saka 1010=1088)⁽²⁴⁾, and elsewhere, record the presence of well organized south Indian merchant guilds or corporations active in the region. They established coastal depots for assembling the camphor, bezoin, pepper and spices so desired by the Chinese from the hinterlands of Sumatra, Java and the Malay peninsula. A chance find of three south Indian style pillar capitals together with brick remains at Tha Rua, near Nakhon Si Thammarat on the east coast of the Malay peninsula, suggests the presence of a south Indian Hindu temple, presumably erected by an expatriate merchant community (Fig. 3).⁽²⁵⁾

Evidence of Indian traders having reached China appears as early as the beginning of the sixth century: a Chinese source lists Indian products presented by a South Indian mission around 510, during the Wei dynasty.⁽²⁶⁾ By the middle of the eighth century the biography of the Chinese priest Kanshin records the presence of Indian merchants and priests in Guangzhou: 'there were... three monasteries of P'o-lo-men [Indian Brahmans] where Brahmans were residing. The tanks in these monasteries contained blue lotuses, particularly beautiful... On the river there were merchantmen belonging to the Po-lo-men [Indians], Po-ssu [Persians], the K'ouen-louen [Malays], and others besides, of which it is difficult to determine the numbers. They were all laden with incense, herbs, jewels and other precious products. The merchandise was piled up in heaps. These ships were 60 or 70 feet...'⁽²⁷⁾ The translation of the Chinese *P'o-lo-men* as Brahmans may reflect a loose nomenclature designating those people from southern India and may not imply that they were all Hindus. The description of monasteries with large tanks however, does suggest that such communities may have been Hindu, since the tank is an essential feature of temple architecture, necessary for the performance of ritual ablutions. The presence of three foreign temples or monasteries in Guangzhou before the mid-eighth century implies a large ex-

patriate Indian merchant community to support them, both resident and migratory. Regrettably no trace of these structures has been identified.

III

In Quanzhou, Fujian Province, architectural and sculptural remains survive of what appear to have been at least two Hindu temples. Two stone pillars and a basement frieze (*vyala-vari*), presumed to be from one of these temples, were first observed forming part of the Kaiyuan Buddhist temple of Quanzhou by Gustave Ecke, who invited A.K. Coomaraswamy to describe them (Figs. 4, 5, 6).⁽²⁸⁾ Since then over 300 stone fragments have been retrieved, many following the demolition of the old city wall, particularly in the vicinity of the Tonghuai city gate to the south-east. The temples may have been located in this area of Quanzhou, although nothing remains which would identify a precise site. The majority of finds were described in Wu Wen Liang's *Quanzhou Zongjiao Shike* ('Quanzhou Religious Stone Engravings').⁽²⁹⁾ Two other stone pillars are installed in the Taoist Tianhou temple in Quanzhou (Fig. 7) and a fifth pillar is now preserved in the Museum of Overseas Communication History, Quanzhou. Among the architectural elements found are two door jambs (Fig. 8) and a startling variety of capitals and reliefs (Fig. 9). Recent finds include a remarkable relief of a seated Durga, located in 1986 in the Xinji Pavilion in Jingjiang County (near Quanzhou), where it is in worship as a Buddhist *kuanyin* (Fig. 10).

Who commissioned and built these Hindu temples? Judging from the architectural remains, there can be little doubt that they were constructed under south Indian direction from detailed plans or pattern books. It is equally clear from the style in which Indian subjects are executed however, that the craftsmen were trained in the Chinese tradition. These Hindu remains would appear then to be the product of Chinese craftsmen working under strict Indian direction: witness the craftsmen's ease with Chinese subject matter, and the sinicizing of motifs in the Hindu reliefs, as seen for example in a crocodile which resembles a Chinese dragon and the sinicized lotus in the *Gajendramokṣa* relief (Fig. 14).

The Kaiyuan temple as seen today, with its two Hindu pillars, and basement frieze forming part of the fabric of the temple, is largely the result of a Ming period renovation. The two pillars are installed on the north verandah of the main hall, the Ta-hsuing-pao-tien, and appear to form part of the original Ming period scheme: note the wooden capitals which they share with the remainder of the Chinese pillars. The columns are of a standard south Indian type, with three square sections interrupted by two sixteen-sided shafts. The four faces of each square section provide the setting for a remarkable series of medallion reliefs. Of the twenty-four medallions, eight depict subjects from Hindu mythology, of which seven are devoted to Viṣṇu

or Kṛṣṇa and only one to Śiva. The subjects depicted are:

- Viṣṇu enthroned with Lakṣmī and Bhūdevī (Fig. 11).
- Viṣṇu seated on Garuḍa (Fig. 12).
- Viṣṇu in his man-lion aspect (*Narasimha avatāra*) disembowelling the cruel king Hiraṇya Kaśipu (Fig. 13).
- Deliverance of the king of elephants (*Gajendramokṣa*): the elephant caught by a crocodile holds a lotus up and appeals to Viṣṇu for salvation (Fig. 14).
- The infant Kṛṣṇa tied to a mortar fells the *Arjuna* tree (Fig. 15)
- Kṛṣṇa subjugating the serpent Kāliya (*Kāliya-damana*) (Fig. 16)
- Kṛṣṇa stealing the cloths of the bathing milkmaids (*gopikāvastrāpaharaṇa*) (Fig. 17)
- Śiva as Bhairava (Fig. 18)

A number of the subjects depicted on the medallions are Chinese in origin:

- a pair of mythical lions chasing a ball
- a pair of phoenixes
- deer in a landscape

The remainder of the medallions are decorative floral designs in the Chinese manner, except for one depicting a pair of interlocking wrestlers, a subject known in Indian temple sculpture (Fig. 19).

The two columns at the Tianhou temple clearly belong to the same series. Coomaraswamy, following Ecke, suggests these are later copies, but having inspected the columns at both temples I see no reason to suggest that they were not originally installed in a contemporary structure, if not the same temple. Their medallions are decorated exclusively with Chinese-style floral and cloud-collar designs, which are imposed onto this Indian architectural order.

Only one Śaivite subject appears among the Hindu subjects, Śiva as Bhairava, a wandering mendicant, seen holding his drum, *triśūla*, noose (*pāśa*) and skull cup (*kapāla*). This panel is out of keeping with the subject matter of all the other column medallions. There is however, a remarkable series of relief panels, some of which were discovered when the city wall was demolished, which are devoted to the veneration of Śiva:

- Devotees worshipping the *līṅga* (Fig. 20, 21)
- A Śaivite goddess, Bhuvaneśvarī or Rājarājeśvarī, enthroned on a lotus and holding a goad and a noose (Fig. 22).
- Śiva Natarāja (Fig. 23)

Two panels of particular interest were retrieved from the walls of a 'paper-stove' wayside shrine in the north-east of the city. They have a special significance in the context of the Hindu remains of Quanzhou, because they depict Śaivite legends which have specific regional associations in south In-

dia. As such, they help to link the patrons of these reliefs with Tamilnadu, and possibly with Thanjavur, the Chola capital served by the port of Nagapattinam, and Tirucchirappalli:

—Elephant woshipping a *liṅga* (*Gajaranya Kshetra*) (Fig. 24).

In this legend the elephant, a devotee of Śiva, each day brought water from the Cauvery river to anoint the *liṅga* and shook the branches of the overhanging tree to allow leaves to fall on the *liṅga* as an offering. A spider wove a web to prevent the leaves falling on the *liṅga* and in the resulting dispute both died, only to be given *mukti* (liberation) by Śiva for their devotion to him. This legend is associated with the district of Tirucchirappalli.⁽³⁰⁾

—A cow worshipping a *liṅga* by bathing it with her milk (Fig. 25).

This panel probably illustrates a scene from the life of the Saivite saint Thirumular, a *siddha* who entered the body of a dead cowherd in order to protect the herd, and subsequently composed a devotional work of 3000 verses in praise of Śiva. These events are recorded in Sundarar's *Tiruttondar-Tokai*, an eighth century Tamil work on the lives of the saints. The subject of a cow bathing the *liṅga* is a popular one, recurring in a number of local myths in Tamilnadu. This legend is associated with the Śiva temple of Gomuktesvara, at Thiruvavaduturai, Thanjavur district, where Thirumular is believed to have performed these miraculous acts in the sixth century AD.⁽³¹⁾

In addition to these reliefs, an unfinished free-standing stone sculpture of Viṣṇu 1.15 metres in height (Fig. 26) has been found. This roughly hewn image was excavated at Nanjiaochang, in Quanzhou, around 1934. It is a cult image of Visnu, represented holding his principal attributes, the conch, disc (*cakra*) and mace. Together with the decorated pillars at the Kaiyuan temple with their predominantly Vaiṣṇavite subjects, this image can be taken to indicate that a lost Hindu temple in Quanzhou was dedicated to Viṣṇu.

However, the discovery of a bi-lingual inscription in Tamil and Chinese in December 1956 in the residential area of Wupan street established that at least one other Hindu temple existed in Quanzhou, dedicated to Śiva. The inscription consists of six lines of Tamil script, with half of the last line in Chinese characters (Fig. 27).⁽³²⁾ As has been observed by the late T.N. Subramaniam the Tamil letters are poorly formed and often erroneous, suggesting that they were executed by a non-Tamil speaker. Dr Subramaniam's translation of the Tamil inscription is as follows:⁽³³⁾

'Obeisance to Hara. Let there be prosperity! On the day Chitra in the month of Chittira in the Saka year 1203, the Tavachchakkarvarttigal Sambandhap-perumal caused, in accordance with the *firman* of Chekachi-khan, to be graciously installed the God Udaiyar Tirukkadalisvar-

am Udaiya-nayinar, for the welfare of the illustrious body of the illustrious Chekachai khan'.

This inscription contains four items of information vital to our understanding of the identity and circumstances surrounding the construction of this Hindu temple. Firstly, it records the installation of an image of the god Hara (Śiva), establishing the religious affiliation of the temple beyond question. Secondly, it states that the image, and presumably the temple which was built to house it, were constructed at the instigation of the religious leader of a Śaivite sect, supported no doubt by the community or guild of Hindu Tamil merchants resident in Quanzhou. Thirdly, it states that the temple was constructed with the written permission (*firman* or *parman*) of the Yuan authorities: indeed, it claims with the express permission of 'Chekachai Khan', possibly a reference to the Mongol emperor or one of his sons serving as a provincial governor, to whose health the temple is dedicated. Fourthly, it bears the date of the installation expressed according to the Indian Saka era, equivalent to April 1281.

What does this inscription, and the lost temple to which it belonged, reveal about the port city of Quanzhou in the late thirteenth century? Quanzhou had begun its rise to prominence in the course of the ninth century and gradually grew to challenge Guangzhou's supremacy as foreign traders became aware of its ability to obtain products from Korea and Japan (with whom Quanzhou had long established trade relations), and to supply products from the Chinese hinterland less easily accessible to Guangzhou. By the eleventh century Quanzhou rivalled Guangzhou, being granted its own Shipping Commission in 1078 for the regulation of foreign trade, and in the early twelfth century the post of Laiyuan was established, making Quanzhou a principal port of the Song government for the reception of foreign missions. In 1350 Wang Dayuan published his description of the products foreign merchants brought to China, including goods such as 'patterned cloth' from Nagapattinam, still the major port of the Coromandel coast for the eastern trade.

Quanzhou was, by this period, home to a large foreign merchant community. Its fame spread as the Arab *Zaytun* (and Marco Polo's *Zayton*). Chau Ju-kua, writing in the early thirteenth century, recorded that in the Yung-li period of the Song period (984-88) a monk from India (*T'ien-chu*) purchased a piece of land in the southern suburb of Quanzhou with the proceeds of gifts from foreign merchants and built a Buddhist shrine there. It was still in worship at the time Chau Ju-kua was writing his *Chu-fan-chi* (Description of Barbarian Peoples).⁽³⁴⁾ The great mosque of Quanzhou (the remains of which are to be seen today in Tumen street), was constructed in 1009 and extensively renovated in 1310.⁽³⁵⁾ It was clearly designed to serve a very large Muslim community, and the numerous Muslim gravestones which

survive record the country of origin of many of the deceased. Inscriptional evidence establishes that as many as seven mosques were known to exist in Quanzhou.⁽³⁶⁾ The gravestones of Nestorian Christians also survive from this period,⁽³⁷⁾ as does evidence of Manicheism.⁽³⁸⁾ These remains clearly establish the cosmopolitan character of Quanzhou.

The construction of the temple of Quanzhou in 1281 may be taken to reflect the level of commercial and diplomatic contact which was being maintained between south China and south India in the late thirteenth century. The dedication of the temple in April 1281 was preceded in February of that year by the despatch of Mongol envoy Yang Ting-pi to India from the port of Quanzhou, underscoring the reciprocal nature of this relationship.⁽³⁹⁾ The despatch of the Yuan envoy was no doubt intended to stimulate foreign missions to China.

The so-called Chinese pagoda of Nagapattinam may also date from this period. Indeed, if it is the temple built at Nagapattinam in 1267 and referred to by Wang Dayuan in 1350, then its construction precedes that of the Quanzhou temple by only fourteen years and suggests that the latter half of the thirteenth century was a period of sustained economic and diplomatic contact between China and India. Yet it was also the end of an era, for the Chola empire was in terminal decline and Chinese overseas trade (which had reached a peak in the twelfth century), was experiencing a decline as a result of the dislocations of the Mongol invasion. By the close of the century the remaining Chola territories had been absorbed into the Pandyan kingdom with its capital at Madurai, and when Chinese trade revived in the decades following the establishment of the Yuan dynasty in 1280, it was increasingly focused on Southeast Asia.⁽⁴⁰⁾

Notwithstanding these shifts in trade patterns, the presence of foreign merchant communities in south India and south China, and the construction of temples to provide for their spiritual needs, confirms the ongoing strength of this commercial relationship. Marco Polo's account of his visit to Quanzhou in 1292, only a decade after the dedication of a Saivite temple in that port, provides a vivid image of this great port and of the exotic commodities which arrived there, most notably from India:

'Zaiton... the port for all the ships that arrive from India laden with costly wares and precious stones of great price and big pearls of fine quality... And I assure you that for one spice ship that goes to Alexandria or elsewhere to pick up pepper for export Christendom, Zaiton is visited by a hundred. For... it is one of the two ports in the world with the biggest flow of merchandise'.⁽⁴¹⁾

The author wishes to thank Yang Qinzhang, Curator of the Museum of Overseas Communications History, for his assistance during visits to Quanzhou in 1983 and 1991. All photographs by the author unless otherwise credited.

Notes

1. Manuel Barradas, 'Discrição da Cidade de Columbo', in B. Gomes de Brito, ed., *Historia Tragici-Maritima*, vol. 1, Lisbon, 1735: 276-7, quoted in S. Subrahmanyam, *Improvising Empire*, Delhi, Oxford University Press, 1990: 85.
2. 'Near the village Welliapaliam stands the Pagode China, a tall tower, formerly built by the Chinese during a certain raid'; F. Valentijn, *Oud-en Nieuw Oost-Indien*, vol. 5, part 1, Amsterdam, 1726: 6. Valentijn drew on Daniel Havart's *Op-en Ondergang van Coromandel* (Amsterdam, 1693), for much of his information. However, Havart, in his discussion of the town and factory of Nagapattinam, does not refer to the Chinese pagoda so it must be assumed that Valentijn, who lived for some years in the Indonesian islands but is not known to have visited the Coromandel coast, gathered this information from another source. I am grateful to Pauline Schleurleer for the above translation and observations on Valentijn's sources.
3. W. Elliot, 'The Edifice formerly known as the Chinese or Jaina Pagoda at Negapatam', *Indian Antiquary*, vol. VII, 1878: 224-25.
4. As recorded in the Kalyani inscription of King Dhammaceti, dated 1476; see Taw Sein Ko, 'A Preliminary Study of the Kalyani inscriptions of Dhammacheti, 1476 A.D.', *The Indian Antiquary*, vol. XXII, 1893.
5. Subrahmanyam, 1990: 84.
6. Lo Hsian-lin, 'On the voyage of Soli Samudra Chola's envoy to China in A.D. 1015', *Proceedings of the First International Conference Seminar of Tamil Studies*, Kuala Lumpur, International Association of Tamil Research, 1968, vol. 1: 513.
7. The use of the term stupa for a tower-like structure is acceptable in a Chinese Buddhist context where the metamorphosis of the bell-shaped Indian stupa into the pagoda tower is well documented.
8. Wang Dayuan, *Dao Yi Zhi Lue Jiao yi*, ('Brief Account of the Barbarian Isles'), original preface dated 1350, edited and annotated by Su Jiqing, Beijing, 1981.
9. Taw Sein Ko, 1893: 45.
10. K.A. Nilakanta Sastri, *Foreign Notices of South India. From Megasthenes to Ma Yuan*, Madras, University of Madras, 1939: 117.
11. *Ts'ien han chou*, quoted in Nilakanta Sastri, 1939: 44.
12. Advances in nautical technology enabled Chinese participation in maritime trade to expand rapidly during the Southern Song period; see Lo Jung-Pang, 'Chinese Shipping and East-West Trade from the 10th to the 14th Century', in M. Mollat (ed.), *Societes et Compagnies de Commerce en Orient et dans l'Océan Indien*, Paris, SEVPEN, 1970: 167-76.
13. S. Beal, *Su-Yu-Ki. Buddhist Records of the Western World*, Delhi, Motilal Banarsidass, 1981 (reprint 1884 ed.): 233n.
14. T.N. Ramachandran, *The Nagapattinam and other Buddhist Bronzes in the Madras Museum*, Madras, Bulletin of the Madras Museum, N.S. VII, no. 1, 1954: 14.
15. For a recent study of these merchant organisations, see M. Abraham, *Two Medieval Merchant Guilds of South India*, Delhi, Manohar, 1988.
16. N. Karashima, 'Trade relations between South India and China during the 13th and 14th centuries', *Journal of East West Maritime Relations*, vol.1, 1989: 60-62.
17. C. MacKenzie, *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society*, vol. 1, : 352-53.
18. The 'Larger Leiden Grant'; for the two Leiden grants see *Epigraphica Indica*, XXII, 1933-34: 167 and 213.
19. According to the smaller Leiden Grant.
20. O. Wolters, *Early Indonesian Commerce*, Ithaca, Cornell University Press, 1967: 250.
21. Tan Yeok Seong, 'The Sri Vijaya inscription of Canton (A.D. 1079)', *Journal of Southeast Asian History*, vol. 5, no. 2, 1964: 17-22.
22. The problematic nature of the evidence surrounding Rajendra I's relationship with Srivijaya is discussed by G.W. Spencer, *The politics of expansion: The Chola conquest of Sri Lanka and Sri Vijaya*, Madras, New Era, 1983: chp. 7.
23. Nilakanta Sastri, 'Takuapa and its Tamil Inscriptions', *Journal of the Malaysian Branch of the Royal Asiatic Society*, vol. XXII, pt.1, 1949: 25-30.
24. Nilakanta Sastri, 'A Tamil Merchant-Guild in Sumatra', *Tijdschrift voor Indische Taal-Land en Volkenkunde*, vol. 63, no. 2, 1932: 314.

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27. Nilakanta Sastri, 1939: 118.
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31. Dr R. Nagaswamy, personal communication. For this and an alternative interpretation, see T.N. Subramaniam, 'A Tamil Colony in Medieval China', in R. Nagaswamy (ed.), *South Indian Studies*, Madras, Society for Archaeological Historical and Epigraphical Studies, 1978: 16.
32. The 12-character Chinese inscription appears to consist of localised phonetic renderings of the Tamil names and does not appear to include a date. I am grateful to Rose Kerr for these observations.
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39. Nilakanta Sastri, 1939: 150.
40. Java, for example, was increasingly competing with south India in the supply of pepper to China.
41. R. Latham (trans.), *The Travels of Marco Polo*, Harmondsworth, Penguin, 1958: 237.

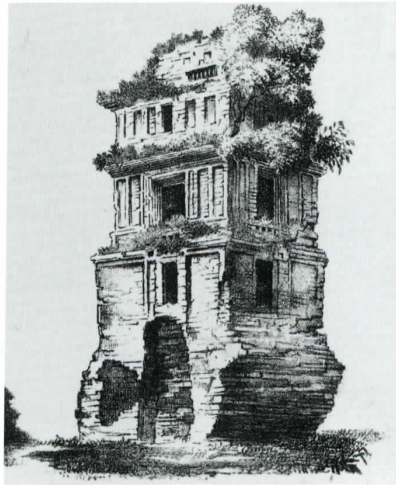


Fig. 1, The 'Chinese Pagoda' of Nagapattinam, as observed in 1846. (after W. Elliot, *The Indian Antiquary*, Vol. VII, 1878)



Fig. 2, Two Buddha images from a cache of five discovered buried in the vicinity of the Nagapattinam pagoda in March 1856. (after W. Elliot, *The Indian Antiquary*, Vol. VII, 1878)



Fig. 3, Stone capital, from Tha Rua near Nkhon Si Thammarat, Thai peninsula. (after H. G. Quaritch Wales, *The Malay Peninsula in Hindu Times*, 1976)



Fig. 4, Kaiyuan temple, Quanzhou(1983)

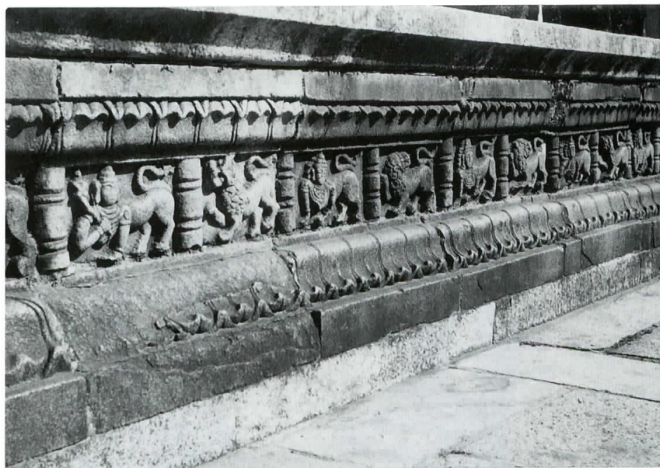


Fig. 5, Bescmcat frieze
of the Kaiyuan temple,
shoing the *vyala-vari*
relief
(Photo : Museum of
Overseas Communications
History, Quanzhou)



Fig. 6, North verandah of the main hall,
Kaiyuan temple, with the two
Hindu pillars(1983)



Fig. 7, Hindu pillar at the Tianhou
temple, Quanzhou(1991)



Fig. 8, Door Jambs with monkey attendant.
Museum of Overseas Communications History,
Quanzhou(1983)

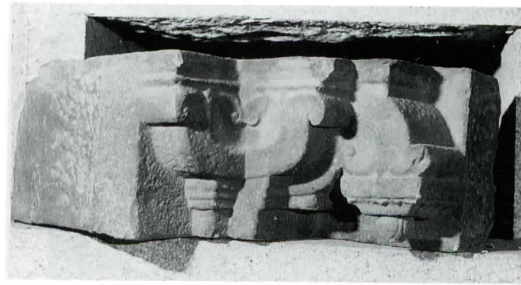


Fig. 9, Capital. Museum of Overseas
Communications History, Quanzhou



Fig. 10, Durga relief, Xinji Pavilion, Jingjiang County, Fujian
(Photo : Museum of Overseas Communications History, Quanzhou)



Fig. 11, Viṣṇu enthroned:
detail from pillar at
Kaiyuan temple(1983)



Fig. 12, Viṣṇu on garuḍa:
detail from pillar at
Kaiyuan temple(1983)



Fig. 13, Narasimha:
detail from pillar at
Kaiyuan temple(1983)



Fig. 14, Gajendramokṣa:
detail from pillar at
Kaiyuan temple(1983)



Fig. 15, Infant Kṛṣṇa:
detail from pillar at
Kaiyuan temple(1983)



Fig. 16, Kālīya-damana:
detail from pillar at
Kaiyuan temple(1983)



Fig. 17, Gopikāvastrāpaharaṇa:
detail from pillar at
Kaiyuan temple(1983)



Fig. 18, Bhairava:
detail from pillar at
Kaiyuan temple(1983)



Fig. 19, Wrestlers:
detail from pillar at
Kaiyuan temple(1983)



Fig. 20, Devotee worshipping linga:
relief from a Hindu temple,
Museum of Overseas Communications
History, Quanzhou



Fig. 21, Devotee worshipping linga:
relief from a Hindu temple,
Museum of Overseas Communications History, Quanzhou

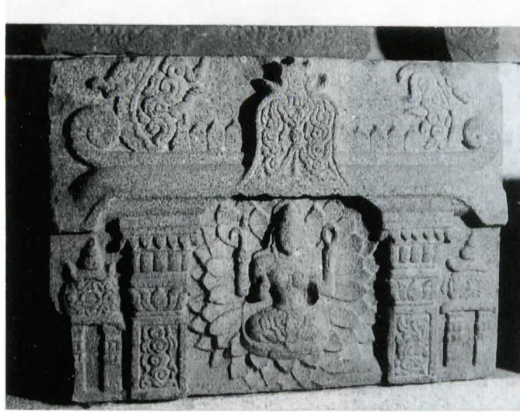


Fig. 22, Śaivite goddess Bhuvaneśvarī or Rājarājeśvarī: relief from a Hindu temple, Museum of Overseas Communications History, Quanzhou



Fig. 23, Naṭarāja (Śiva as the Lord of dance): relief from a Hindu temple (lost). after Wu Wenliang, *Quanzhou Zongjiao Shilo*, 1956



Fig. 24, Elephant worshipping linga: relief from a Hindu temple, Museum of Overseas Communications History, Quanzhou



Fig. 25, Cow worshipping linga: relief from a Hindu temple (lost). after Wu Wenliang, *Quanzhou Zongjiao Shilo*, 1956



Fig. 26, Viṣṇu, found in Quanzhou.
Museum of Overseas Communica-
tions, Quanzhou

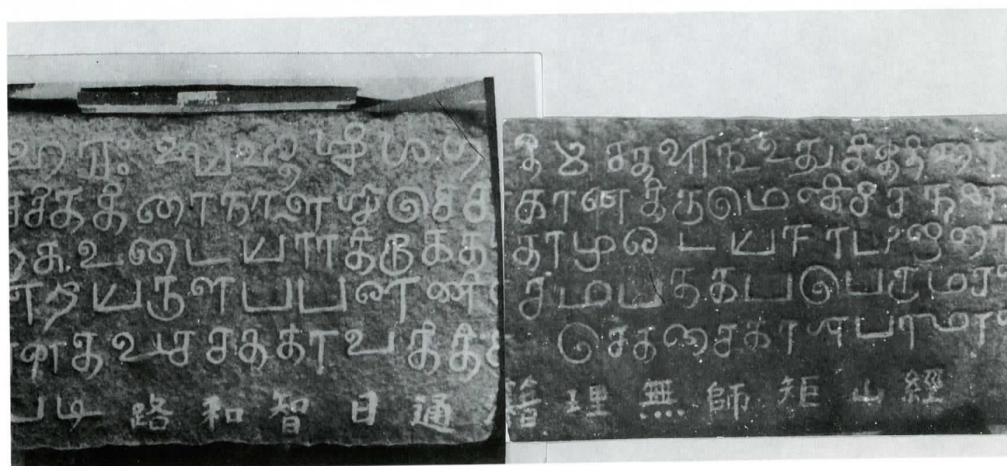


Fig. 27, Tamil and Chinese bi-lingual inscription, found in Quanzhou.
Museum of Anthropology, Kiamen University, Fujian